# Table column widths

By default glu sizes table columns automatically: each column ends up as wide as its content needs. A `width` on a `<td>` or `<th>` overrides that measurement, so the layout stays put however long the text turns out.

## An even split that stays even

The classic case is a signature block. Both cells declare `width: 50%`, so the right-hand column starts at the same position in both tables even though they hold different amounts of text.

| | |
|---|---|
| Place, date | For the client |

| | |
|---|---|
| Berlin, 3 March 2026 | For the contractor, represented by the managing director |

Leave the widths out and each column shrinks to its own content, so the two blocks drift apart and the signature lines no longer align.

## Percentages and absolute lengths

A percentage resolves against the width of the table, an absolute length is taken as it is. A percentage is therefore only as meaningful as the table it refers to: a table shrinks to its content unless told otherwise, so the stylesheet sets `table { width: 100% }` first.

| | |
|---|---|
| 25 percent | 75 percent, so this column is three times as wide as its neighbour. |

| | |
|---|---|
| Exactly 4 cm | Whatever is left over: declaring a width for only some columns is fine, the undeclared ones share what remains. |

## Sizing a Markdown table from CSS

Pipe tables have nowhere to put a `style` attribute, so their columns are sized from the stylesheet with `nth-child`. Wrapping the table in a `<div class="terms">` gives the rule something to hook onto: the table is a descendant, not the element carrying the class. Name `th` and `td` alike, or the header row keeps its automatic width.

```
.terms table th:nth-child(1), .terms table td:nth-child(1) { width: 22% }
```

| Property | Value | Effect |
|---|---|---|
| `width` | percentage | Share of the table width. |
| `width` | length | Fixed column width, e.g. `4cm` or `120pt`. |
| `width` | omitted | Column is measured from its content. |

## What the width really promises

A declared width is the column's preferred *and* minimum size.

| Situation | Outcome |
|---|---|
| Content needs more room than declared | It wraps, and is never clipped: a word too long to fit still widens the column. |
| Widths add up to more than 100% | All of them scale down proportionally. Two columns asking for 80% each end up with 50% apiece. |
| Width on a cell spanning columns | Ignored: it belongs to no single column. Declare it on a row without `colspan` instead. |